

DR ANOOP K. GANJOO

A Bubble of Privileges

FOR MOST MEDICAL SCHOOL ASPIRANTS IN INDIA, AIIMS has always held a pride of place, and so it was for me too in 1974 when I joined this prestigious institute. A large campus, an impressive modern building, its various departments having abundant resources for cutting-edge equipment, its library stocked with all kinds of books, latest journals and later electronic literature search facility, an Olympic-size swimming pool, a large gymnasium with outdoor tennis and basketball courts, individual hostel rooms for all students, and a film club that regularly showed avant-garde indie movies sourced from the many foreign embassies in Delhi were part of what made AIIMS attractive. But I think there were two more significant features that added to its appeal: a small class size, the smallest in the country (only 50 undergraduates per year, though this number was increased later) allowing great camaraderie among the students, and a brilliant teaching faculty, some of whom were invited from their established positions in prominent institutions from India and abroad. Many of them were our role models.

We were surrounded by an environment that fostered not just academic brilliance but personal growth and development as well. I would say a robust, free and mutually respectful faculty-student relationship was a major highlight of my stay at the institute. For a long time, AIIMS offered us opportunities not available in other medical colleges and there were constant exchanges with prominent Indian and foreign doctors and researchers (including some Nobel laureates). We felt we were in a bubble of privilege.

There was an expectation of academic and medical excellence from us, as was a subtle understanding that most of us would be teachers and researchers (nearly half of my class started their professional careers as teaching faculty, in India and abroad). Quite a few AIIMS pass-outs have made a name for themselves in the medical world, holding key leadership positions. Private practice in those days was frowned upon, being seen as profiting unfairly from a patient's ill health.

Over the years, especially with the entry of corporates in the medical field, much of the exclusive image that AIIMS enjoyed has dimmed somewhat though it continues to maintain its pole position among the medical schools of this country. The central government is trying to replicate its success by opening several sister AIIMS centres all over the country and some of these are indeed doing better than the best medical facilities in their respective states. But with major strides made in the medical field in the last few years and the growth of good corporate hospitals, an increasingly aware patient population does not necessarily prefer an overcrowded government set-up like AIIMS over private entities (which however was a norm in our time there).

"Centres like AIIMS shall continue to inspire young minds that choose medicine over a plethora of career options"

When I look back, I am pleased with the progress in India's medical field; we are among the best in the world in many areas. A testimony to this is the international acceptance of India as a destination for advanced medical care. But there is a sad side to this growth too. The altruistic nature of medical practice is giving in to the demands of commerce, which I firmly believe is a reflection of the changed zeitgeist of current times. Medicine is no longer a calling, the noble profession (a much-abused cliché) that it was touted to be. A doctor, expected to place care of the patient above all else, ignoring personal aspirations, is no longer as privileged in society as he was earlier and is often reviled and viewed with suspicion. It is unfair to expect doctors to sacrifice their personal and social lives in the service of patients, for an underwhelming remuneration, and still be subject to societal violence when things go wrong. No wonder, the field of medicine does not attract the same number of bright school students as before.

Be that as it may, centres like AIIMS shall continue to inspire thousands of young minds that choose medicine over a plethora of career options available now. ■

The author is a senior cardiothoracic and vascular surgeon at Indraprastha Apollo Hospitals, New Delhi. He passed out of the AIIMS in 1978